By the end of 1571, Akbar had decided to move permanently to Sikri, ‘to silence the babble of the common throng’ regarding the maleficent ghouls haunting Agra Fort. ‘The Emperor built a lofty palace on the top of the hill of Sikri,’ wrote Badauni, and ‘a high and spacious mosque of stone so large that you would say it was a part of a mountain…in the space of about five years the building was finished and he called the place Fathpur and he built a bazaar and baths and a gate.’ In addition to the palaces and gardens and bazaars, Sikri would solve the ‘vexatious question’ that Akbar’s growing harem posed. A separate, sequestered space was built especially for the women, ‘a large enclosure with fine buildings inside where he reposes’, wrote Abu’l Fazl, and which now would be carefully guarded. From the clearly bombastic claims of 5,000 women that Abu’l Fazl speaks of to the more modest number of 300 that Monserrate puts forward, it is difficult to assess exactly how many women there really were. Abu’l Fazl was undoubtedly exaggerating so as to highlight the Padshah’s power and benevolence in gathering all these women, symbolically representing the different peoples of Hindustan. As for Monserrate, he would never have had access to the women’s quarters himself. Nonetheless, there were clearly dozens of wives and concubines, with their attendant large retinues, as well as all the other women—the foster mothers, the aunts, the sisters, the visitors, the dispossessed relatives and so on.

There were other eclectic visitors to court at this time and one of the first Jain visitors Padmasundara wrote ‘one of the first Sanskrit works ever to be commissioned by the Mughals’. This was a work called the *Akbarasahis Garadarpa* (Mirror of Erotic Passion for Shah Akbar) and, according to historian Audrey Truschke, the Jain was one of the first authors to openly reflect a cross-cultural milieu. In his introduction, Padmasundara created one of the first Sanskrit texts to use a Koranic name for God, Rahman, to describe Akbar…

> The entire world shines with his splendor such that it blinds the eyes.
> Our welfare rests in him like a genuine jewel, always and forever.
> He stands beyond the darkness and is called Rahman, the highest point.
> O Akbar, crown jewel of Shahs! May that light always protect you.